

## » NAVDEEP SINGH

**Category:** Athletics (Men's Javelin Throw F41)

Navdeep Singh secured India's seventh gold medal in the men's javelin throw F41 category, an event for athletes of short stature. After narrowly missing the podium at the Tokyo Paralympics three years ago and the Asian Para Games last year, the 23-year-old's perseverance finally paid off.

Initially, Navdeep won silver, but this was upgraded to gold after Iran's Sadegh Beit Sayah, the original gold medallist, was disqualified for violating Rule 8.1 of the World Para Athletics Rules and Regulations (Code of Conduct and Ethics). Navdeep's personal best throw of 47.32 metres was reinstated as the new Paralympic record.

Born prematurely in 2000 in Panipat, Haryana, Navdeep's challenges began early. His parents realised he had dwarfism when he was two years old, setting the stage for a life filled with challenges. Growing up, he endured not only the rigours of training but also cruel taunts from onlookers. His father, Dalbir Singh, a former national-level wrestler, provided unwavering support, encouraging him to pursue athletics.

Navdeep began his athletic journey at the age of 10, initially trying his hand at wrestling and sprinting before discovering his passion for javelin throw. He made a remarkable international debut at the 2017 Asian Youth Para Games in Dubai, where he claimed gold. He followed this with another gold at the 2021 World Para Grand Prix in Dubai.

However, his journey wasn't without setbacks. Disappointing fourth-place finishes at the Tokyo Paralympics and the Asian Para Games in Hangzhou tested his resolve. Yet, Navdeep never gave up, earning a bronze medal at the World Para Athletics Championship in Kobe earlier this year.

As the track and field competitions came to a close at the Paris Games, Navdeep's golden throw ensured the Stade de France echoed with the Indian national anthem, solidifying India's growing legacy in javelin on the world stage.

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